ever since the time of Locke, epistemology has been a prolegomena to any serious metaphysics in the West. Indian philosophy bestowed serious attention upon the question of the origin and validity of knowledge much earlier than did philosophy in the West. Both in India and in the West, a distinction has always been drawn between opinion and knowledge, between rumor, hearsay, or the personal whims of an individual and what is regarded as psychologically valid sources of knowledge. Obviously every source of knowledge cannot be recognized as acceptable. The question therefore is asked as to what and how many are those independent sources through which alone we rightly acquire our knowledge of fact. *This question of the valid sources of knowledge is not to be confused with the related question of the truth of the knowledge thus acquired.* The question "How do we know what we know?" and the question "How do we know that what we know is true?" are two entirely different questions, and must be constantly kept apart if the issue of authority as a valid means of knowledge is to be clearly apprehended.

In Western philosophy, sense perception and inference have been regarded as the commonly accepted instruments of knowledge since the beginning of the Renaissance, and Western philosophers have almost unanimously accepted the exhaustiveness of these two sources and have seldom questioned their adequacy. Indian philosophers, on the other hand, recognize that our entire body of knowledge at no period of time could be completely accounted for or explained by sense perception and inference alone. We always know much more than can be accounted for by our own perception or inference. In fact, it is incontestable that at any given time verbal testimony accounts for nine-tenths of our stock of knowledge. The question, therefore, is, "Should authority be recognized as an independent and valid means of knowledge?" To answer this question, we must know, first of all, what authority is and what exactly is meant by testimony? Gautama, as one of the greatest expounders of authority, defines authority or "word" in his *Nyāya-sūtra*—the classical text of the traditional "Logical school" of Indian philosophy—as "the assertion of a reliable person,"[2] and this definition stands generally accepted and adopted by all other Indian systems. A reliable person is further defined in the *Nyāya-bhāṣya* on the same *sūtra* as one "who possesses the direct and right knowledge of things, who is moved by a desire to make known [to others] the thing as he knows it, and who is fully capable of speaking of it."[3] It is interesting to note here that the Nyāya system does not mean by authority divine revelation or